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ILLUSION OF PEACE

A warlike general turned into a surprise peddler of solutions to history's problems. India, too, had a gifted pacifist in Vajpayee. But it was too fraught a time for even the boldest entrepreneurs of peace



It may call for a particularly tolerant psychiatrist to understand the tics of split personality that India and Pakistan exhibit towards each other. Contrary emotions coexist. Hate is like a sibling feud—the obverse of the coin exists too, and becomes manifest in the most schizoid fashion. Peace follows war follows peace. After Pokhran-II and its ricochet across the border, Atal Bihari Vajpayee had sallied boldly forth on a bus to de-escalate matters. But Lahore led to Kargil. At that stage, the well-set batsman would wait for the reverse swing. Sure enough, it came. Only the source was surprising.

Gen. Pervez Musharraf, the very man who had prosecuted war in the summer of 1999, was the one who now came waging peace. He had overthrown Nawaz Sharif in a coup d'état in 1999, installed himself as president, and was reinventing himself as a latter-day Ataturk. His formula did not lack in innovative audacity. Back when he sent his men in stealth mode to occupy the icy promontories of Kargil, he had already shown a healthy disregard for the Line of Control. Now he was proposing that the two countries dissolve it altogether—in a formal pact—and turn it instead into a passage. Not for gun-toting fidayeen, for there would be no more need for them. Kashmir would be shared, open territory linking the two countries, a cultural and human crossroads.

If anyone could pick him up on that, it was Vajpayee. He had his own ingenious knack for the unconventional, a silvery gift of the gab,

> "Uncomfortably for India, a section of opinion makers in Pakistan perceive the invitation for talks as a sign of weakness and a vindication of Pakistan's stand on Kashmir.... Vajpayee's May 23 initiative appears impulsive—not one that has come after months of strategising and calibration."



India-Pakistan: What Can They Talk?
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